

Ethical Concerns for Judges

As an ISEF judge, you are an adult in a position of authority when dealing with any ISEF finalist. Here we discuss four consequences of your position of authority:

1. You must treat every ISEF finalist fairly and with respect,
2. You must report unfair or disrespectful behavior you observe by any other person toward any ISEF finalist,
3. You must not solicit any personal contact information from students, nor provide your own personal contact information to them, and
4. You must not be a judge in a category for which you have a conflict of interest with any of its projects.

1. Responsibility for Yourself

When you volunteered to be a Grand Award judge, you agreed to a Judge Ethics Statement, reprinted below as Appendix I to this document. That agreement incorporates the Society for Science Program Harassment Policy, reprinted below as Appendix II. Briefly, all judges have agreed to a standard of behavior that treats all ISEF finalists with dignity and respect. This is not a burdensome requirement. It is simply “doing your job.” Respectfully interviewing each ISEF finalist is all that is expected of you. See also Appendix III on Data Protection.

2. Responsibility for Others

As a Grand Award Judge, you are responsible for the well-being of all ISEF finalists.

Although it is exceedingly unlikely, it is possible that you will observe *another* judge not adhering to the expected code of conduct. If so, bring your concern to one of your category co-chairs. You may want to clarify your understanding of the situation you observed through a brief conversation with the impacted student. If you do so, do not promise to do anything other than alerting Fair authorities. Do not take matters into your own hands and confront the judge at issue.

ISEF has provided a *separate* mechanism by which students themselves may report inappropriate judge behavior to the Fair.

It is also possible, though again unlikely, that during the introductory portion of one of your interviews you may learn of a situation in which the student had an uncomfortable interaction with an earlier judge. Again, in this case, tell your category co-chairs, making clear that you did not observe the reported behavior, but are only forwarding the student’s concern.

Appropriate behavior is expected of everyone, independent of role. This applies equally to Special Award judges (SAO judges) and to Grand Award judges. No adult in the project display area should ever behave disrespectfully toward any student.

3. Communicating with Students Outside of ISEF Judging

Sometimes a judge will be particularly impressed with a student's work and will feel prompted to help the student in developing the project further. There is a right way, and a wrong way, to establish communication with students after the fair.

- No judge should request personal contact information from any student.
- Similarly, no judge should provide his or her own personal contact information to any student.
- If you wish to communicate with a student after the fair, give your preferred contact information, and the intended student's project number, to your category co-chair who will forward your request to the proper Fair authorities.

4. Conflict of Interest

At ISEF we strive to avoid not merely *actual* conflicts of interest, but also any appearance of impropriety. For this reason, no judge is allowed to serve in a category for which there could be a real or perceived conflict of interest. When you submitted your application to be an ISEF judge you agreed to disclose any conflict of interest and were asked to identify any such conflicts that you knew about so that you would be assigned to a category without conflicts.

All conflicts of interest have a single defining characteristic: it is a conflict of interest for a judge to have any substantial connection with a student (or students) presenting a project in the category¹ to which the judge has been assigned.

There are two types of conflicts of interest:

1. **Official Party.** If you are a member of the official party of an ISEF-affiliated fair, then it is a conflict of interest for you to be a judge in the same category as any student from "your" fair.
2. **Personal Connection.** If you have personally worked with the student in any capacity, or personally know the student, then it is a conflict of interest for you to be a judge in that student's category.

"Personally worked with the student" includes any interaction which is direct, such as the student worked in your laboratory or the student consulted repeatedly with you during the course of his/her project. It is NOT a conflict if your interaction has been limited to a handful of emails where the student asked questions and moved on.

"Personally know the student" means that you or the student would recognize each other without prompting. Examples include living in close proximity to each other, the student is the child of a close personal friend, or you and the student have a biological relationship of second cousins or closer. It is NOT a conflict if your personal connection has at least two degrees of separation. For example, if your child and the student attend the same school, this does not

¹ Category is the important level, not subcategory. Subcategories will not be isolated from one another either during the interviews (all judges will interview both inside and outside their subcategory) or during the caucusing (when any project in the category may be compared against any other). In contrast, different categories are completely isolated from each other in all judging activities.

constitute a conflict unless the student is a close personal friend of your child, or has otherwise spent time in your home.

Importantly, **there is no conflict of interest arising from any prior service as a judge**, having merely interviewed or evaluated a particular project in a previous science fair. A conflict exists only if there was direct non-trivial contact with the student during the production of the project. Merely judging the project is a very different type of interaction.

While there are clear examples of situations that are, and are not, conflicts of interest, there is no hard line precisely defining all situations. In deciding whether you have a potential conflict of interest, please consider how it would look should the situation become publicized. Exercise reasonable caution.

Resolution

If you discover that you have a conflict of interest with any project in your assigned category, you must inform the Chair of Judging immediately. The earlier you discover a conflict, the better.

- You should be able to discover any conflict in the weeks leading up to the Fair when all project materials are provided to you online for your review. In this case, report your conflict to the Chair of Judging so that you can be reassigned to a different category.
- If you do not discover the conflict until after you register and receive your interview schedule, immediately tell your category co-chairs who will, in turn, inform the Chair of Judging.

Whenever a judge has a conflict of interest, he/she will be assigned to a different category.

Non-Resolution

- It is not sufficient that a judge simply not interview a project with a conflict of interest.
- Similarly, it is not sufficient to promise not to vote on such projects or others vying with it for awards during the final category caucus.

Judges are not allowed to serve in a category where their presence may create a real or perceived conflict of interest.

Points of Emphasis

1. Simply put, as a judge, do your job. Do not attempt to take advantage of your position.
2. If you observe another adult behaving inappropriately toward any student, report your concern to your category co-chairs.
3. Any communication between judge and student outside of interviews on Wednesday must be set up through the agency of the Fair.
4. You must avoid even the appearance of a conflict of interest with any project in your category.

Appendix I: Judge Ethics Agreement

Source: Judge Application, <https://judges.societyforscience.org/Apply/Complete>

Ethics Statement

I hereby acknowledge that by submitting this application:

1. I agree to serve as a judge for the International Science and Engineering Fair 2023.
2. I agree to act in a positive and ethical manner, treating each student finalist I encounter fairly and respectfully.
3. I will keep confidential any privileged information obtained through my volunteer service. I will not use such information, nor disclose it to third parties.
4. I agree to disclose all conflicts of interest resulting from direct competitive, collaborative or other relationships with any of the student finalists.
5. I acknowledge that I have read and agree to abide by [Society for Science's harassment policy](#) protecting all ISEF participants from harassment and sexual harassment by another ISEF participant or other person for any reason including, but not limited to: age, national origin, race, color, religion, gender, sexual orientation, marital status, disability, ancestry and/or veteran status and understand The Society's responsibility to investigate claims of violation of the policy.
6. I agree to notify my co-chairs and/or the judging chair immediately if I become aware of any circumstance that would compromise either (a) my ability to attend the event or (b) fairly evaluate finalists' projects.

☐ I have read, understood, and agree to the above ethics statement.

Appendix II: Society for Science Program Harassment Policy

Source: <https://www.societyforscience.org/harassment-policy/>

General

The Society prohibits harassment of any student, volunteer, or employee by another student, volunteer, employee or third party for any reason including, but not limited to: age, national origin, race, color, religion, gender, sexual orientation, marital status, disability, ancestry and/or veteran status. Harassment includes but is not limited to slurs, epithets, threats, derogatory comments, unwelcome jokes, and teasing. In online formats, harassment includes cyberbullying, trolling, the use of bad language, sexually explicit language or imagery, political attacks, racist language or imagery, personal attacks and posts that demean, insult, threaten or belittle other's work. Any person who feels that he or she is a victim of such harassment at a Society program should promptly report the matter to a Society employee or other adult authority who will immediately present to the proper authority. Upon receipt of any allegation(s), an investigation will be initiated. All such reports will be handled as confidentially as possible. The Society may take appropriate disciplinary action against any person found to have violated the harassment policy. No adverse action or retaliation will be allowed to be taken against a person who reports a violation or who participates in an investigation of this policy in good faith.

Sexual

Sexual harassment of or by any person in attendance at a Society program is prohibited. Sexual harassment includes but is not limited to unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and/or verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature including, but not limited to, drawings, pictures, jokes, teasing, or uninvited touching.

In accordance with this policy, unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, sexual demands, or other verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature will constitute sexual harassment when:

- The conduct has the purpose or effect of unreasonably interfering with an affected person's performance, or creating an intimidating, hostile, or offensive environment; or in third party situations, one or more individuals are reasonably offended by the sexual interaction, conduct, or communications between others.
- The conduct has the effect of creating actual, perceived, or potential conflicts of interest, favoritism, disruption or lack of objectivity.

If a Society employee or adult volunteer becomes aware of such a situation, he or she is under a responsibility to contact the proper authority. Knowingly false accusations are prohibited and will be treated by disciplinary action comparable to that which would be applied to actual misconduct.

Appendix III: Data Protection Policy

Source: <https://judges.societyforscience.org/Login/PrivacyPolicy> (First page of Judge Application)

By receiving and or using the data gathered by The Society about our participants, you are agreeing to treat all data as strictly confidential information and obligated to protect these individual's information from misuse and exploitation. Any personal data may not be copied, transferred or otherwise processed unless the Society has agreed hereto. If any information has been compromised while in your possession, you are agreeing to alert The Society immediately and provide full details of the breach.